

high-traffic area, and he basically told me to shove it. I asked for a double bed and he told me two singles would have to do.

The creaky elevator took as long to get to the fourth floor as the Chinese took to build the Great Wall. The bellboy showed us to a garish, tawdry little room in the back. The single mattresses were so worn and soft that when I sat on the bed I slid to the floor. I told the bellboy I wanted to change rooms. Rather than try to explain the problem, he took me to the room next door. The mattresses there were just as bad. When I insisted he do *something*, he pulled two plywood boards from the room across the hall and shoved them under our mattresses. The price for all this "luxury": \$225 a night.

Make the comparison yourself. Go to Rome or Paris and spend a night in the Hyatt, Intercontinental, or Georges V. Then go to an ordinary hotel, where European tourists might stay, near the Spanish Steps in Rome or the Sorbonne in Paris. Ask yourself if the difference is worth \$150 a day, over \$1,000 a week.

Most luxury hotels have beautiful lobbies. To enjoy them, check in at a simple hotel around the corner and go to the beautiful lobby for drinks. You'll pay two or three times more for your martini than at a local bar. But the total tab will be only a couple of bucks, not an extra \$150 a night. The main luxury hotel in Montevideo, Uruguay, is the Victoria Plaza. When in Montevideo, Vicki and I go to the piano bar there. We meet people in the lobby there. We buy international papers and read them in the lounge there. But we *stay* in an \$8-a-night hotel three blocks down the street.

The rule is:

Choose hotels that offer what you need and nothing more

Don't pay for elevators, phones, TV, air-conditioning, news-stands, restaurants, and other things you'll rarely use. Choose basic hotels in the center of town. Look for a clean room,